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[GS PAPER II – INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS • GS PAPER III – INTERNAL SECURITY] | **Publication Date: 05/10/2026**

WHAT HAPPENED ON THE FLYDUBAI AIRCRAFT



The article examines the in-flight altercation aboard a flydubai flight, the emergency response, diversion to Saudi Arabia, and the role of crew and passengers in ensuring a safe landing. It also highlights concerns surrounding aviation security, unlawful interference, emergency protocols, and international coordination in civil aviation.

WHAT HAPPENED ON THE FLYDUBAI AIRCRAFT

Syllabus areas:

GS Paper II – International Relations

GS Paper III – Internal Security

Flight Diverted After In-Flight Pilot Assault



On September 30, 2026, at around 8:35 a.m. IST, a flydubai flight travelling from the United Arab Emirates to Israel was diverted to Saudi Arabia following a serious in-flight incident involving its pilots.

The incident occurred aboard Boeing 737-8 MAX flight **FZ 1073**, which was carrying predominantly Israeli passengers. One pilot reportedly stabbed the other and allegedly attempted to crash the aircraft. The flight was subsequently

diverted to **Tabuk, Saudi Arabia**, where it landed safely despite sustaining significant damage.



Following the incident, fly Dubai announced the suspension of all flights to and from Israel. Authorities have launched an investigation into the incident, including examination of a possible **terrorism-related motive**.

What happened on the flight?



According to media reports, an altercation reportedly broke out between the two flight crew members during the journey, resulting in one pilot being stabbed. The captain, **Smit Machchhar**, an Indian national and former SpiceJet pilot, had joined flydubai in 2022. The co-pilot, who was reportedly arrested following the incident, has been identified in media reports as an Omani national. Both crew members were subsequently shifted to Abu Dhabi after receiving initial medical treatment in Saudi Arabia.



Media reports, eyewitness accounts and videos recorded during the flight indicate that passengers were caught amid considerable confusion and panic, particularly near the front section of the aircraft.

According to reports by **Reuters** and *The Times of Israel*, citing a spokesperson for Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, the injured captain reportedly managed to open the cockpit door after being attacked. This enabled several Israeli passengers to enter the cockpit and restrain the alleged attacker. Other flydubai pilots who were present in the passenger cabin reportedly intervened and helped ensure that the aircraft landed safely in **Tabuk, Saudi Arabia**.

Weapon Used and Condition of the Crew

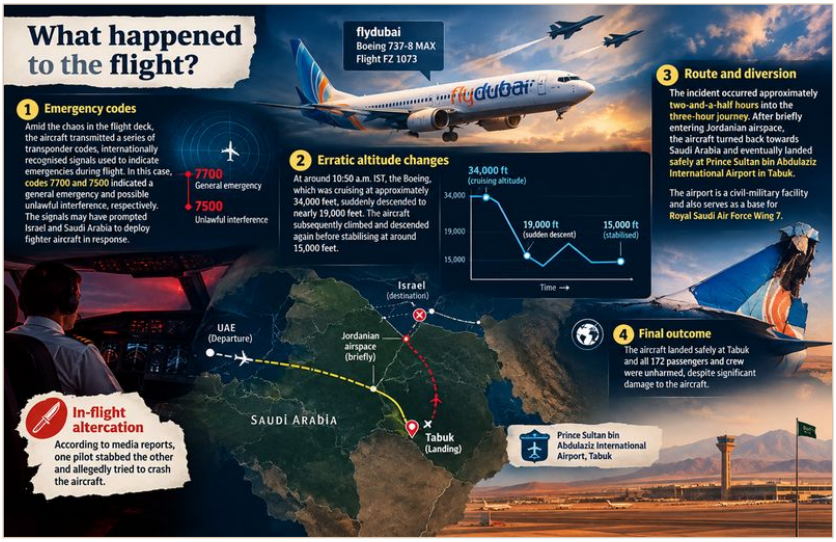
Initial accounts from passengers suggested that a **pocket knife** may have been used during the attack, while other reports indicated that the aircraft's **flight-deck crash axe** could have been involved. However, a BBC report on October 3, citing the United Arab Emirates Prosecutor General, stated that the pilot was **attacked with a crash axe in an alleged attempt to take control of the aircraft**.



Senior pilots told *The Hindu* that a crash axe is a **mandatory emergency safety tool** carried for use by flight crew. It is generally kept in the flight deck in an easily accessible location and may be used during emergencies, including breaching the fuselage when structural deformation occurs or opening panels to access the source of smoke or fire.

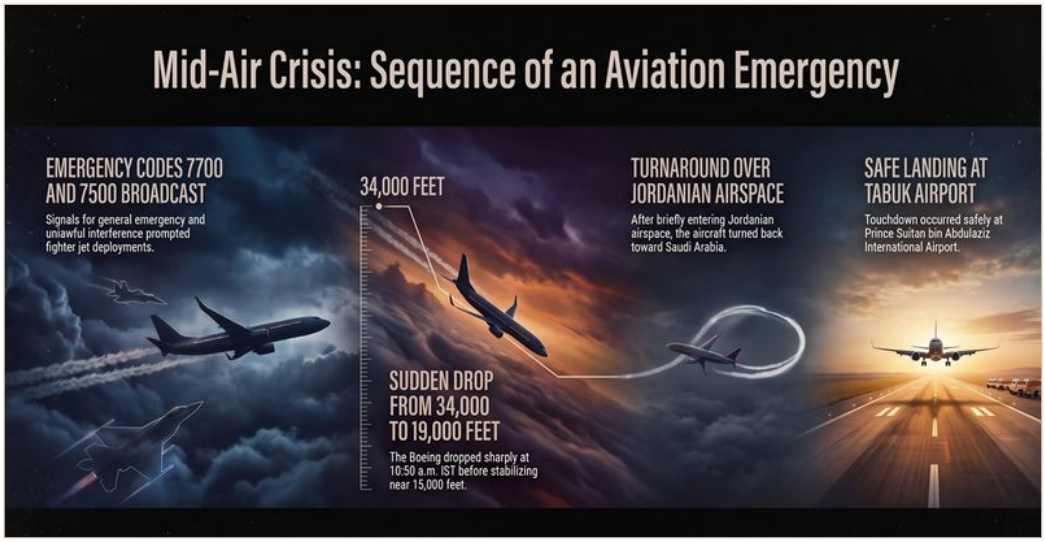
A video shared with *The Hindu* by aviation sources reportedly showed both pilots on the cabin floor with serious bleeding and bloodstains visible on the cabin wall. One pilot appeared to be wearing a blood-soaked uniform with epaulettes, while the other was seen using an oxygen mask. Several passengers near the injured crew members were reportedly heard asking that the incident not be filmed.

What happened to the flight?



Amid the chaos in the flight deck, the aircraft transmitted a series of **transponder codes**, internationally recognised signals used to indicate emergencies during flight. In this case, codes **7700 and 7500** indicated a general emergency and possible **unlawful interference**, respectively. The signals may have prompted Israel and Saudi Arabia to deploy fighter aircraft in response.

At around **10:50 a.m. IST**, the Boeing, which was cruising at approximately **34,000 feet**, suddenly descended to nearly **19,000 feet**. The aircraft subsequently climbed and descended again before stabilising at around **15,000 feet**.



The incident occurred approximately **two-and-a-half hours into the three-hour journey**. After briefly entering **Jordanian airspace**, the aircraft turned back towards Saudi Arabia and eventually landed safely at **Prince Sultan bin Abdulaziz International Airport in Tabuk**. The airport is a **civil-military facility** and also serves as a base for **Royal Saudi Air Force Wing 7**.

Aircraft Damage and Emergency Landing

An emergency descent can be carried out in a controlled manner. However, if the descent is **erratic or uncontrolled**, it can place significant stress on critical flight-control surfaces and potentially cause structural damage, including to the aircraft's tail section.



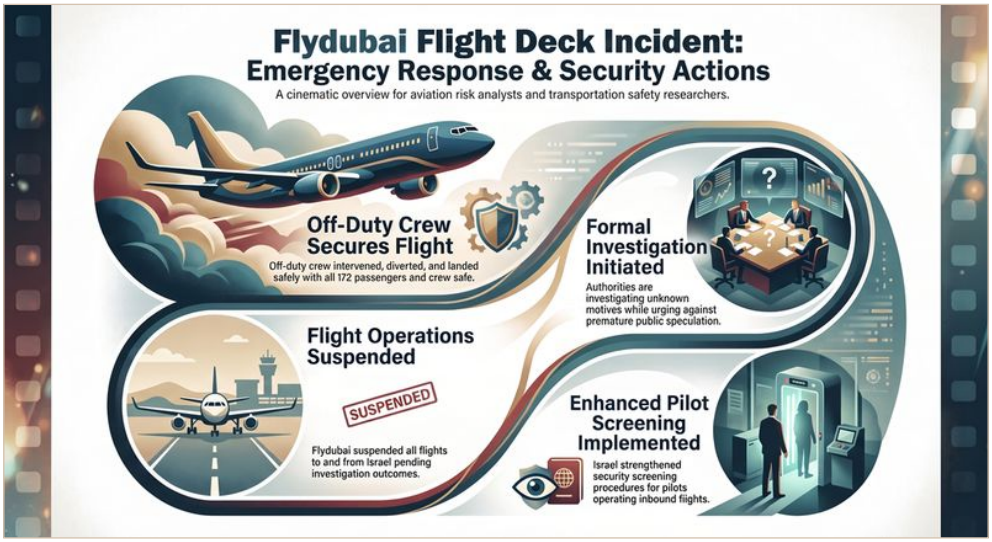
Images taken on the ground at **Tabuk** reportedly showed substantial damage to the aircraft's **rudder and vertical stabiliser**, with a large portion of the structure appearing to be missing. Passengers were seen disembarking from the aircraft using a **step ladder operated by Saudi Ground Services Company**, the airport's ground-handling agency.

The airport authorities stated that their **Air Traffic Control (ATC) centre received a distress call** from the aircraft, in which the crew requested permission for an **emergency landing**.

What Has the Airline Said?

In statements shared with *The Hindu*, a **flydubai spokesperson** confirmed that an **altercation had occurred in the flight deck** during the flight. The spokesperson stated that the aircraft was subsequently secured by **off-duty flydubai crew members travelling on the same flight**, who intervened, diverted the aircraft and successfully landed it with all **172 passengers and crew members safe**.

The airline said that the **reasons and motives behind the incident remain unknown** and are subject to a formal investigation. It urged all parties to avoid premature conclusions or speculation while authorities continue to establish the facts.



Flydubai also announced that **all flights to and from Israel would remain suspended** while the investigation into the incident is underway.

How Is the Investigation Proceeding?

Authorities have initiated a **formal investigation** into the incident, while aviation experts have drawn comparisons with previous cases involving suspected **unlawful interference or deliberate actions by flight crew**.

Earlier incidents of this nature include **Japan Airlines Flight 350 (1982), Royal Air Maroc Flight 630 (1994), SilkAir Flight 185 (1997), EgyptAir Flight 990 (1999), LAM Mozambique Airlines Flight 470 (2013), and Germanwings**

Flight 9525 (2015).

In response to the incident, **Israel has decided to strengthen security screening procedures for pilots operating flights into the country**, as authorities examine the circumstances and possible motives behind the incident.